

REFLECTION

Ships Like Mountains

A cruise on the Atlantic, and Surah Ar-Rahman

On a cruise ship in the middle of the Atlantic Ocean, looking at the huge decks stacked like a building and at the sea all around, one ayah came to my mind.

In Surah Ar-Rahman (55:24):

وَلَهُ الْجَوَارِ الْمُنشَآتُ فِي الْبَحْرِ كَالْأَعْلَامِ ﴿٢٤﴾

"His are the ships raised high on the sea like mountains."

Three words

- **Ships:** الْجَوَارِ (*al-jawaari*), literally "the runners", the ones that glide along.
- **Raised high:** الْمُنشَآتُ (*al-munsha'aat*), built up, lifted up.
- **Like mountains:** كَالْأَعْلَامِ (*kal-a'laam*); an عَلَم is a landmark, a mountain you can see from far away.

The people who first heard this had seen nothing like a modern liner. Yet the ayah fits it perfectly. And notice the first word: وَلَهُ "and His". We build the ship, but the sea, the wind, the iron and the minds that design it all belong to Him.

The next ayah asks the question of the whole surah (55:25):

فَبِأَيِّ آلَاءِ رَبِّكُمَا تُكَذِّبَانِ ﴿٢٥﴾

"So which of the favours of your Lord will you deny?"

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